

Readings

First a non-apology. Then a pseudo-apology.

Seth Myers and Amber Ruffin

Amber comes on stage and sits in a chair by Seth. She punches him in the face.

Seth: You just punched me in the face.

Amber: I categorically deny those allegations.

Seth: You just punched me!

Amber: Did I? That doesn't sound like me. Anyone who knows me would say that that's very out of character.

Seth: Amber, you came out here, sat down, and punched me in the face.

Amber: I remember those events differently.

I'm sorry your face feels punched.

Seth: That's not an apology.

Amber: Seth, it was a different time back then.

Seth: It was 30 seconds ago!

Amber: Me? Punch someone in the face? Look, I've always been a supporter of faces. Some of my best friends have faces.

Bicycle

Note found on a bicycle:

"Apologies. I stole your bike last night in the final chapter of a beer fueled rampage. Smooth ride though! Great bike choice. 10/10 Would steal again!"

The Art of the Apology: Eating Humble Pie With Grace

Properly deployed, the apology is an incredibly powerful tool of reconciliation and relationship repair. It brings self-transformation, genuine connection with another and increases trust. A well done apology is a super power. That said, it's still uncomfortable.

Recently I heard a speaker say that an apology has 3 parts. "I did it. - I was wrong. - I regret it." If any of those parts are missing, it's not an apology. This gave me the idea for a sermon. Soon after that, I was walking with a friend and I told her I was going to preach on this business of begging pardon. Well, because I like to practice what I preach... You see where this is going.... in this same walk I made a terrible faux pax and said her that her son was being a jerk. I know better than that. She can say something negative about her son, I should not! Fortunately, my friend told me that I had hurt her by my words. I felt terrible! I wanted the floor to open up and swallow me. And I had to quickly remember everything I know about how to apologize. At least I had the good graces to thank my friend for telling me I'd offended her. Ugh! As much as I think of a skillful apology as a super power, I absolutely hate needing to do it!

I'm not alone here. Some folks refuse to admit they blew it. It may be that they don't know how. Others fear that saying they are sorry will make them look weak, or that admitting a mistake will open them up to a litany of all the other sins they have committed. It may be that they don't separate their character from their actions. If they do bad, they must be bad. They may experience the feeling of shame as overwhelming. They may fear that if they accept responsibility for wrong-doing, the other person won't have to own up to their part. And of course, some folks are hoping that if they don't bring up their misdeeds, the other party will just forget all about it and things will go back to normal.

Here's the thing though, not only can a good apology restore what has been damaged, it can even make things better. When we acknowledge that we offended someone, we let them know that we

see them. So often when we hurt someone, it's because we weren't paying attention. When we specifically address what we did wrong, we're signalling that we are self-aware enough to know how our actions caused harm. This is one of the reasons why it is important to be specific when we confess foibles. A general "I'm sorry" does not really let the person know we can be trusted not to do the offense again. All we've really told them is that we wish things didn't feel bad.

It's also helpful when we get to the part where we're ready to make amends if we can talk about particulars. Instead of just promising that I'll never say something stupid again, I can promise that I will remember not to speak ill of my friend's son. I recognize the damage that I did and vow that I won't do it again. Chances are, however, that I will put my foot in my mouth some other way!

We also would do well to use the words "I'm sorry" and "I apologize." It signals that we have remorse about what we did. Few things feel more unsatisfying than when someone tells us that they're sorry our feelings got hurt. That's not really an apology. In fact, it seems that we are being blamed for being too sensitive, or that somehow we misunderstood. The other person is not taking responsibility for any psychic wounds. But "I'm sorry," "I apologize," or "I regret what I did" indicate that this is an apology. It is not simply an explanation.

It can be tempting to focus on how terrible we feel about the offense. This is a good place to remind ourselves that we are not the center of the discussion and our emotions are not paramount. While I do want my receiver to know that I felt very bad, or feel very bad, it's vital that they understand that their pain is what matters most.

Part of the superpower of an apology is that it increases our empathy. We are putting ourselves in the other's shoes.

Let me add here that it is okay to explain. It is not okay to excuse. An explanation, particularly if I can point to how I might avoid a similar circumstance in the future, is more than fair. An excuse, though, does not take responsibility for what was done. In order for

this act of contrition to have validity, we have to own our actions, or our inactions. And doing so helps rebuild trust.

This matters even if we didn't mean to cause harm. Most often we don't set out to hurt another. It's important to remember that our impact matters more than our intent. "I didn't mean to hurt you" is not a stand alone apology. We need to be accountable for the outcome of our actions.

It is in that vein that we ask what we can do to make things right. We offer to make amends. Sometimes we can make things better. Beyond promising to avoid making the same mistake, there are times we can effectively speed up the healing time. It may be that there is something we can do that relates particularly to what we botched. We can clean up some messes. Sometimes we can simply perform a nice gesture.

While researching apologies, I came across one phrase that I thought was charming: "Please accept my sincere apologies, and this chocolate!" A little extra thoughtfulness can go a long way in reconciliation!

I mentioned that a good mea culpa can be a superpower; it can even make a relationship better than it was before the mis-step. When we confess our wrong doing and genuinely express remorse, we indicate to the other that they have been seen. Few things are more impactful than truly being seen. In our admission of bungling something, we recognize the other person's feelings as well as their values. We "get them" on a deeper level. When we specifically own up to what we did wrong, we promise that we'll avoid that offence in the future. We are declaring ourselves trustworthy.

Perhaps most strikingly, we demonstrate that we are willing to be uncomfortable for the sake of the other person and the relationship. We are cognizant of the need for second chances and grace. Relationships become a lot more spacious when both parties know there is room for mistakes and reparation. There is more safety and solidarity.

Apologies are so consequential that research shows that even saying "I'm sorry" for things that we can't control builds trust and empathy. "I'm so sorry you were stuck in that horrible traffic." "I'm sorry your boss was such a knucklehead!"

In essence we're communicating that while I know I am not responsible for your happiness, I want you to know that I am seeing you. You are seen and I don't want this for you. I am here for you. All ideas that increase kindness.

When I spoke to some of my colleagues about this research, we had a great discussion. Several shared that they aren't comfortable with the wording "I'm sorry." Instead they will clarify by saying "I'm sorry that" - fill in the blank. I tend to be even more of a stickler and use the phrase "I'm sad that" X happened to you. Still, these studies put out by the Harvard Business School are intriguing. Apologies do matter!

Back to the story of my faux pax and my friend. She had the courage to tell me that I blew it. As much as I wanted the earth to open up and swallow me, I am so grateful she said something. Most of us, about 95%, are conflict avoidant. It is hard to tell someone that they offended us. It requires a certain amount of faith in the other person and the relationship to say something.

If I'm honest, I will bring myself to confront someone only if the other person and our connection really matter to me. I'm not willing to put myself through such stress if I don't trust the other person to respond well or if I'm not invested in them.

As awkward as it was to hear I'd messed up, I understood that the information was a gift, and a pricey one at that. I'm glad I remembered to thank her for telling me.

In all this talk about begging pardon, it's important to note that an apology does not erase consequences, even if it is graciously accepted. Whatever damage was done needs to be repaired. Even

chocolate does not take away consequences! Time and right action are necessary to rebuild trust.

There is some disagreement about ending a concession of misdeeds by asking for forgiveness. Some declare that it is common sense to clearly request it. Others claim that asking for forgiveness puts the other person on the spot. If the forgiveness is forced, it's not real. Instead some suggest that one simply state "I hope you can forgive me." That has a grace to it.

It goes without saying that in circumstances where the wounding has gone both ways, proffering an apology does not guarantee that we will receive one in return. And it undermines the sincerity of our confession if we are doing it to get one back. Instead, we make our amends without expectations of any outcomes. We do it because it is the right thing to do.

We also do it because the soul searching, empathy and humility necessary for a good apology changes us. We examine the situation from the other's perspective and we come away with a different view of ourselves and our actions. A well executed admission of guilt and expression of remorse actually increases our strength. Despite our feelings of shame and embarrassment, we demonstrate a certain level of ego strength and assurance of our own worth when we admit our foibles. Apologies do not reside in weakness and it builds internal fortitude when we perform them well.

When I think of good apologies, I'm reminded of the tale relayed by the manager at a fast food restaurant. He writes that one evening he filled an order. The customer looked at his receipt and checked his food and said that everything looked good. Half an hour later, the phone rang and it was the customer's wife. She was wildly upset because she didn't get her onion rings. The manager told her that he was sincerely sorry and that he'd be happy to replace her onion rings and throw in a free order to make it right. The woman said that she was too worked up to drive over to pick them up. It had ruined her night.

Later that evening, the manager noticed that a new review for the restaurant had come in. It was a one star review from the woman, complaining that she hadn't gotten her onion rings.

The next day, while he was doing his usual check of reviews, he saw another review from the same woman... except this time it was five stars.

Her review said: "I need to apologize! Yesterday I left a 1-star review because I thought the restaurant forgot my onion rings. Turns out my husband ate them all on the drive home. I'm so sorry! I don't know how to delete a review, so here's a five-star review instead. Actually, I'm leaving FIVE five-star reviews to make up for it!"

Sure enough, she left four more glowing five-star reviews throughout the day, all with variations of 'my bad, he was just hungry.'

Not only did the woman own up to her mistake, she took steps to make things right. Unfortunately, the story doesn't tell us what the husband did!

Let me offer one other example, because it is a masterclass apology, and it's from a corporation. Their mea culpas usually backfire.

This one was brilliant.

In 2013, Skittles changed the flavor of their green candies from lime to green apple. People were incensed! As a matter of fact, the public complained about this atrocity for 9 years! In September of 2021, not only did the Skittles corporation return their green candies to the beloved lime flavor, they made a big production of their apology!

First they held a 35 minute live press conference on Twitch, Twitter, and broadcast it in Times Square. Over 136,000 people watched. Then they posted a formal apology to the 130,880 people who had complained online. It took 10 hours and 54 minutes to read the post with all their names. Plus they sent everyone of those people a free bag of lime Skittles!

Rather than brushing off the complaints or turning the problem on the customers, Skittles thoroughly owned their mistake. In response, the Skittles searches increased by 1,000%. The store sales

rose 200%. Package sales shot up 21% and their dollar sales rose 7.4% for the year, reaching the highest point in the brand's history. The whole thing was well done and a great example of how such an act of contrition can be a superpower. They ended up in a stronger position financially and image wise after their apology than before the whole debacle.

As a final note, owning up to our mistakes plays right into the Zeigarnik Effect. This is the principle that we let go of something once it is completed. Research shows repeatedly that if we acknowledge our fault to an offended person, both parties are apt to forget the incident. They may remember there was an upset, but often can't recall what the problem was about. When there is no apology, both parties carry it forward and don't forget. We remember unfinished business. This is just another reason to say "I'm sorry."

Chances are I haven't told you a great deal you didn't already know. My hope is that today's sermon will encourage you to take the steps necessary to bring about reconciliation. If you need to tell someone they have hurt your feelings, do so with compassion and trusting that things can be rectified. If you are the offending party, be quick to apologize. And if you aren't sure if you should say you're sorry, err on the side of rebuilding your relationships. Heck, you can even say you're sorry for things that you can't control as an expression of care and empathy.

May you be astute enough to know when you've blown it.

May you be compassionate enough to put yourself in another's shoes.

May you be grateful for the gift of confrontation.

May you be skillful in your efforts to rebuild and make things right.

And may you embrace the strength and love of well made apologies.

Amen and amen.